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Daniil Starikov

Research Interests

Primary Political Economy, Development, Economic History
Secondary Behavioral Economics, Sports Economics

Education

University of Chicago, Harris School of Public Policy Chicago, IL
Ph.D. in Public Policy Studies Sep 2024 – present
Area of Focus: International Policy and Development

Higher School of Economics (HSE) & New Economic School (NES) Moscow, Russia
B.A. in Economics (summa cum laude) Sep 2020 – Jul 2024

Additional Education

Pompeu Fabra University (UPF) Barcelona, Spain
RECSM Summer Methods School Jul 2023

Working Papers

“Equilibrium Behavior in Sequential Games: Evidence from Formula 1” (with Dmitry Dagaev and Gleb Vasiliev) [\[PDF\]](#)

Abstract: We study equilibrium behavior in a naturally occurring multi-period sequential game. Using detailed telemetry data from Formula 1 races, we analyze strategic pit-stop interactions between closely competing drivers, who repeatedly decide whether to act or wait while anticipating their rival’s response. We first estimate how the timing of both drivers’ decisions affects the probability of overtaking and use these estimates to characterize the payoffs of the sequential game, optimal responses, and equilibrium behavior. We then compare the model’s predictions with observed decisions. Drivers respond systematically to their rivals’ actions, and their responses broadly follow the comparative-static patterns implied by the model. However, we find substantial heterogeneity across teams: some exhibit response patterns considerably closer to the model-implied best responses than others, and closer adherence to these responses is associated with greater success in strategic interactions. Our results provide field evidence on equilibrium behavior in a sequential game in which the same agents make repeated, state-dependent decisions.

Work in Progress

“The Threat of Faith: The Determinants and Legacies of Soviet Anti-Religious Repression”

Abstract: Religion has rarely faced state power as total as the Soviet Union’s. Atheism was official policy for seven decades, and the state closed or destroyed 84 percent of the Orthodox churches standing in Russia in 1917. The campaign was nonetheless selective, and this paper asks what governed it and what it left behind. The evidence is a new dataset covering the near-universe of those churches – 21,238 buildings – with closure, destruction, and reopening dates, materials, and types recovered from free-text histories by a large language model. Even an unconditional ideological aim, the results show, was carried out like a constrained optimization. Facing limited enforcement capacity, the state acted first on the churches it most valued suppressing: older and larger buildings, those near past unrest, and those in places where the security apparatus was strong and the local church stock too sparse to strain it. Historical religiosity accounts for only part of the pattern. Conditional on acting, the disposal decision tracked reuse value: prominent masonry churches were closed and converted to secular use, while wooden and dilapidated ones were demolished, most sharply in the Stalin years. Using plausibly exogenous variation in repression built from these determinants, mainly the physical composition of the local 1917 stock, the paper estimates the long-run effect on religiosity today and finds it faint. Repression is associated with somewhat lower service attendance and a lower stated importance of religion, by 0.1 to 0.3 of a standard deviation, but with no measurable change in religious affiliation, identity, or belief. A cohort analysis indicates that these near-null local effects are most consistent with an impact of repression that operated at the national and generational level rather than locally, and with a partial recovery of religiosity since the Soviet collapse.

Pre-PhD Research

“Economics of Superstars under Hard Salary Cap: a Study of the National Hockey League”

Abstract: The superstars who can boost the performance of their team, at the same time, can increase the inequality that may mitigate the positive effect of superstars and even make hiring them unfavorable. In this paper, I model this trade-off by

focusing on the National Hockey League (NHL) teams that operate under a hard salary cap. Then I estimate the parameters of the model using the data on the salaries of the NHL players, and the model suggests that teams should hire superstars under these conditions. Further, I study the potential heterogeneity of the effects and find out that top players are less vulnerable to adverse inequality effects and benefit from the presence of superstars more than other players. Moreover, I get that superstars may slightly decrease the performance of their peers who compete with them for time on ice, but the effect on the players with other roles is strictly positive. Based on these results, the NHL teams should hire the superstars but not create competition among them.

Research Experience

Intern researcher at the Laboratory of Sports Studies (HSE)	Sep 2022 – Aug 2024
RA to Prof. Michele Valsecchi (NES)	Sep 2023 – Mar 2024
RA to Prof. Marta Troya-Martinez (NES)	Jun 2023 – Dec 2023
RA to Profs. Maxim Alekseev (HKUST) and Namrata Narain (Boston University)	Jul 2023 – Oct 2023

Teaching Experience

University of Chicago	Fall 2025 – present
TA for Cost-Benefit Analysis (Prof. Robert Kaestner, <i>Spring 2026, Fall 2026</i>)	
TA for Principles of Microeconomics for Public Policy I (Profs. Navin Kumar, Sheng-Hao Lo, and Lesley Turner, <i>Fall 2025</i> ; Profs. Damon Jones, Navin Kumar, and Lesley Turner, <i>Fall 2026</i>)	
Higher School of Economics (HSE) & New Economic School (NES)	Fall 2021 – Spring 2024
TA for Applied Microeconometrics (Prof. Olga Kuzmina, <i>Spring 2024</i>)	
TA for Macroeconomics-2 (Prof. Konstantin Styrin, <i>Spring 2024</i>)	
TA for Microeconomics-2 (Prof. Oleg Baranov, <i>Fall 2023</i>)	
TA for Corporate Finance (Prof. Sergey Stepanov, <i>Fall 2023</i>)	
TA for Differential Equations (Prof. Ilya Schurov, <i>Spring 2023</i>)	
TA for Microeconomics-1 (Prof. Andrei Savochkin, <i>Spring 2022</i> ; Prof. Dmitry Dagaev, <i>Spring 2023</i>)	
TA for Calculus-1 (Prof. Ilya Schurov, <i>Fall 2021</i> ; Prof. Dmitry Dagaev, <i>Fall 2022</i>)	

Academic Service

New Economic School (NES)	Spring 2026 – present
Head of the Problem Setting and Grading Team, NES High School Economics Competition	
All-Russian Schoolchildren's Olympiad	Mar 2023, Mar 2024
Member of the Jury and Appeals Committee, Economics Olympiad (Moscow, 2023; Kazan, 2024)	
New Economic School (NES)	May 2023
Problem Author and Grader, NES High School Economics Competition	

Conferences and Seminars Talks

Reading Online Sport Economics Seminars (ROSES)	Jun 2024
XXV Yasin (April) International Academic Conference	Apr 2024

Achievements & Scholarships

Awardee at Student Research Paper Competition (HSE)	Dec 2024
Awardee in the category "Best Research Paper in Economics for Master's Students and Graduates of 2024"	
Honorary Diploma "Bachelor of Excellence"	Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma for outstanding achievements in studies, teaching and research with a monetary reward	
Honorary Diploma for one of the best bachelor theses on HSE & NES Joint Program	Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma from academic council of HSE & NES Joint Program with a monetary reward	
Best Teaching Assistant 2024 on HSE & NES Joint Program	Jul 2024
Honorary Diploma after Prof. Andrei Bremzen for the best Teaching Assistant 2024 at HSE & NES Joint Program with a monetary reward	
Gazprombank Scholarship	Oct 2023
Personal scholarship for success in educational and academic activities	
Awardee at Olympiads for Undergraduate Students	2020
<i>Economics</i> : HSE "Higher League" Olympiad (2023, 2024)	
<i>Finance and Investments</i> : HSE "Higher League" Olympiad (2023)	
Scholarship "For the Greatest Externality" (NES)	Oct 2021

Personal scholarship for helping other students and being an active and useful member of the student community

Awardee at Olympiads for High School Students

2020

Economics: NES High School Economics Competition (2020), Moscow Olympiad (2020)

Mathematics: Phystech Olympiad (2020), “Lomonosov” Olympiad (2020), Rosatom Olympiad (2020), Moscow Olympiad (2020)

Skills

Languages Russian (Native), English (Fluent), Spanish (Beginner)

Programming Python, Stata, R